



THE FIGHT FOR AMERICA'S FAMILIES

Exposing the Corruption in Family Courts and CPS.

They took my kids. They tried to silence me. They WON'T.

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 41

SOUTH CAROLINA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside South Carolina's family courts and child-welfare system.

60

SOUTH CAROLINA FAMILIES ON
RECORD · 96 CHILDREN IMPACTED ·
19 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
OF PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED
MAY 10, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
16 OF 46

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

SOUTH CAROLINA AT A GLANCE.

Across 60 South Carolina families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 96 59 of 60 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$141,000 median across 43 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 19 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 55.0% 51.7% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 60	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.6	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 59 of 60	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 16

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so South Carolina families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02

THE COST OF SOUTH CAROLINA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	46	\$30,000	\$153,922	\$7,080,398
Lost Wages	33	\$30,000	\$145,030	\$4,786,000
Other Court Fees	26	\$3,000	\$11,444	\$297,550
Therapy / Evaluations	31	\$7,000	\$12,248	\$379,690
Reunification Services	20	\$3,000	\$8,155	\$163,100
GAL Fees	38	\$10,000	\$18,799	\$714,359
Asset Loss ¹	24	\$90,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (43 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$141,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$90,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		19	1.6 yrs
Mean months lost		29	2.4 yrs
Total across all families		1,087	90.6 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · SOUTH CAROLINA

Most families documenting in South Carolina are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		24	40%
Not provided		24	40%
Case closed: within last 2 years		6	10%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		3	5%
Active case: progress being made		1	2%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		33	55%
Family Court Only		21	35%
Unknown		4	7%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		1	2%
Family Court		1	2%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		21	35%
3 – 5 years		13	22%
5 – 10 years		7	12%
6 months – 1 year		7	12%
Over 10 years		5	8%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		20	33%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		14	23%
Full Custody		9	15%
50/50 Joint		8	13%
Children in Foster Care		5	8%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Charleston		8	13%
Greenville		5	8%
Richland		4	7%
Lexington		3	5%
Spartanburg		2	3%
Anderson		2	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		26	43%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		9	15%
High Conflict Divorce		7	12%
Other: (Short answer)		6	10%
Other		3	5%

04 PARENT VOICES — SOUTH CAROLINA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable South Carolina comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



It has financially destroyed me and broken me emotionally. The legal abuse alone has broken me into a person I don't recognize.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Richland County Court has continued to ignore evidence of neglect and abuse towards the children. Refuses to acknowledge litigation abuse. and if you're the defendant, you might as well forget it you will forever be guilty. There's no due process but haste, dramatic, major [...]

— SOUTH CAROLINA PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM SOUTH CAROLINA

Family court is where justice goes to die. All judges, attorneys, guardians ad litem, evaluators, law enforcement, child protection agencies, and anyone involved in this process in any way should be thoroughly trained and have a complete understanding of trauma and coercive [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They destroyed our family. I'm a widow, my boys and I have already lost so much. We didn't deserve this.

— SUSAN

The system has traumatized my family while allowing the abuser to lie, conceal assets, dismantle a business, and still be awarded over \$100,000 in attorney's fees.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I rebuilt my life in 4 years from nothing when we left our abuser to 6 figure salary, purchased two homes, children had security, and I was healing and thriving. Alienation claims and a notoriously corrupt attorney have taken it all away to punish us but despite the gift of PTSD [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system took my children based on assumptions instead of facts, leaving us emotionally broken and fighting to be heard. No parent should lose time with their children because no one stopped to verify the truth.

— LAURA

This system has destroyed my family over false allegations and lies.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has taken my children, ripped children from their sister based on false allegations that were used knowing what the “temporary” order would entail, and almost 2 years later nothing has changed.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my life and ruined my child.

— VIRGINIA

Expose how corrupted they are and made and my children experience the worst thing ever!!!!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has destroyed me and my babies mentally, and emotionally. Cause finance damage, and causing struggle

— LAWANNA

“The system repeatedly fails the ones that need it most- innocent children by enabling abusers and adding more victims to their lists. In my case, it’s his second go around and it’s “pay to play” in SC family court as I sadly continue to hear,. Around here they follow the money [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Tormented my children and myself by enabling our abuser to the point of suicidal ideation in a 9 year old!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has attempted to viciously fracture my role as a mother and deteriorate my ability to provide as a newly single parent. Instead of helping us out of an abusive situation- it has acted as a method to harm us further with institutionalized and legal abuse.

— BRENNNA

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Allowed my exwife to remove me from my son's life and replace me with her new husband. Years later she still emails my place of work claiming making false claims even after my rights were terminated.

— BRENT

On top of not being able to parent my son, after years of him being in our home, my step-children have been traumatized, and my wife has been beyond depressed. The harm inflicted upon my family is immeasurable.

— THOMAS

The Family Court System was used control and abuse me by an abuser that loves to fool legal system to do the abuse for them. They feel more powerful that way and I just learn that there is just more pain if I ask for help.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The South Carolina Family Court system failed my children and destroyed my motherhood. Until we have more court actors trained in Coercive Control and Domestic Violence children and families will suffer.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The impact of my experience with the court system extended far beyond legal proceeding. This altered the course of my family's stability, challenged my sense of security, and required a level of strength I continue to draw on every day.

— DONNA

They underestimated a mother's strength—no matter what this system has done, I'm still standing, and I'm coming for my son.

— PAULETTE

Completely restored not only hope in justice but teaching my son that bad behavior and lies gets rewarded

— EDEE

That have taken my child from me . I have narcissist and domestic violence.. He has a drinking problem, smoking MJ sex addiction

— JAYME

I don't know where to even start it has been a total nightmare. My children and I have lost all hope that anyone will help them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Family court gave my abuser custody of two of my children with no DNA proof of relation. The oldest of the two was not his but the court claimed phycological parent, the younger was never DNA tested even when I asked for it.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system took my child for two months for no reason, she got ahold of my straightener burnt her leg it healed fine went to 4 pediatric doctors, as well as an abuse doctor at the Julie Valentine Center, they refuse to give me the report from JVC and getting me for physical [...]

— BAILEY

They have torn my daughter from me 2 weeks after n her father died. Took her away from her brother. Broke our bond. Broke my heart. Ruined our lives!

— SHONNA

No proof given was defaulted got annilated

— ANDREW

The system has caused irreparable harm to my family. My youngest child atill hasn't dealt with the trauma she has experienced. She is terrified to be away from us now. Family court is a child trafficking ring and needs ABOLISHED!

— PETER

It has destroyed the relationship of a child, parent, and entire family. Caused medical issues such as a bipulmonary embolism. Fear of retaliation and inability to fight for or protect a child. I am speaking for my husband as he has been gagged due to my social media.

— NICOLE

The Charleston County Family Court system, aligned with a vindictive parent, tore apart our happy family, caused trauma beyond imagination, and made it hard to even get out of bed many mornings.

— KATE

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



“I went from being my son’s primary and only caregiver to suddenly losing him through a court process I was not properly able to participate in, and years later I am still fighting to rebuild the bond that separation damaged. This system cost me precious time with my child, my [...]

— GIGI

Malicious fracturing of attachment

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Multiple people in the DSS system repeatedly apologized and said this should never happen. I don't trust DSS leadership, I learned they are a love, hate relationship. We were great for 3 years, and then in the final hearing so many lies. DSS turned on us. In the end our [...]

— STEPHEN

The family court system has failed myself and my daughter greatly by turning the abuser into the victim and giving him full power over our lives. Ten years in and my daughter’s mental health will be impacted forever.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has taken everything from me, torn my family apart at a cost/debt that will be paid ultimately by my children. Everyone close to me has been affected and are at a loss.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I reported concerns my child raised of department of social services. Due to multiple reports being unfounded I've lost primary custody. My ex is military and deployed and the judge is leaving my child with the step mom. Despite never being notified and her not having [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has left us fighting for our peace and safety while being told I need to trust the man who has abused me for years and continues to use the courts to hurt me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We have lost so much time, and now my daughter does not want to see or speak to me

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Knowingly Prying on the bereaved., Using my already diagnosed mental health cause More mental anguish mental distress mental harm to my family, soul bound

— ROBIN

46 South Carolina parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 40 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — SOUTH CAROLINA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from South Carolina families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

It has financially destroyed me and broken me emotionally. The legal abuse alone has broken me into a person I don't recognize.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court is where justice goes to die. All judges, attorneys, guardians ad litem, evaluators, law enforcement, child protection agencies, and anyone involved in this process in any way should be thoroughly trained and have a complete understanding of trauma and coercive control. The danger being imposed on children and families due to the family court crisis and lack of knowledge is unimaginable. There is nothing I have seen yet that is in the best interest of the child in this court system. It needs to be held accountable, scrutinized, reviewed, and reformed! My kids will be in therapy for life after the hell we are going through. It's all a racketeering scheme. It's truly disgraceful. More needless families will be torn apart, people will continue to lose their lives, or their livelihoods until there is real change!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Richland County Court has continued to ignore evidence of neglect and abuse towards the children. Refuses to acknowledge litigation abuse. and if you're the defendant, you might as well forget it you will forever be guilty. There's no due process but haste, dramatic, major changes that traumatize parents, and children for years, waiting for resolution. Richland County family Court will push a parent and a poverty just to preserve a court order even if that parent didn't have the ability to pay child support. They now garnish 60% of my check every two weeks and I can no longer even pay my rent and they don't care.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They destroyed our family. I'm a widow, my boys and I have already lost so much. We didn't deserve this.

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I rebuilt my life in 4 years from nothing when we left our abuser to 6 figure salary, purchased two homes, children had security, and I was healing and thriving. Alienation claims and a notoriously corrupt attorney have taken it all away to punish us but despite the gift of PTSD they expect us to continue to suffer from, we have found our hope in God's love, justice, and mercy. Praise God for His renewal and peace in the midst of our persecutions and suffering!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

“I went from being my son’s primary and only caregiver to suddenly losing him through a court process I was not properly able to participate in, and years later I am still fighting to rebuild the bond that separation damaged. This system cost me precious time with my child, my financial stability, and years of emotional pain no parent should have to endure. I believe my ex-partner Kenneth latchford has used custody and separation as a way to punish and exclude me from my son’s life, and I have felt that prejudice and hostility toward me and my Latina family played a role in how we were treated and pushed aside by him and his mother April Plummer enabled by the court system including the GAL Leslie Armstrong.”

— GIGI

Malicious fracturing of attachment

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Multiple people in the DSS system repeatedly apologized and said this should never happen. I don't trust DSS leadership, I learned they are a love, hate relationship. We were great for 3 years, and then in the final hearing so many lies. DSS turned on us. In the end our granddaughter has been adopted. We see her all the time.....She asks us all the time why she could not live with us. Greenville SCDSS is evil, they lie and manipulate, they create orders, (not always legal) and then Cherry Pick how the order outcome should be--its not about the child!

— STEPHEN

The family court system has failed myself and my daughter greatly by turning the abuser into the victim and giving him full power over our lives. Ten years in and my daughter’s mental health will be impacted forever.

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Knowingly Prying on the bereaved., Using my already diagnosed mental health cause More mental anguish mental distress mental harm to my family, soul bound

— ROBIN

The system has taken my oldest son from a large, loving family with over 30+ extended family members including three siblings that miss him dearly, and given him to a mentally sick chronically single woman who lives with her mentally sick chronically single mother. It has robbed us of every penny my wife of 12 years and I had in our retirement, savings, and bank accounts. It continues to pull us back and impose extra fines for inability to pay previous fines. We have three small children and are now forced to give up our home due to financial ruin.

— ARTHUR

Since I have my kids I have always been another one thing that I always been there never left them through the good in the bad we always been together. You came in and excited if you was big and bad Alexis Haywood and you stole my child from me. Who had no evidence no proof the back of what you said and what you did you just made of alligator and they running with it which is so wrong. I pray God have mercy on your soul

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The system along with my cousin and drive away so deep between me and my daughter that I don't know that it could ever be fixed and they allowed that to happen

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Too much to write here.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Financially destroy me, a father who doesn't even want his daughter just use her to destroy and hurt me, loss of trust in the system, my daughter withdrawn and in emotional distress at 6 years old

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Motivated me to expose it. All of it. Husband hid cameras in my house- secretly recording me. Had to hire 5 lawyers. Family, case law, dss, wiretapping, criminal. Women that don't have several hundred thousand dollars to fall back on never see their kids and go to prison for things they didn't do in these situations. God has saved us. The system has failed us.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

46 full approved South Carolina comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this South Carolina report comes from South Carolina respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in South Carolina — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 60 South Carolina families reporting here are not the universe of South Carolina families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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